# The Altar Today

***Living Sacrifice, Royal Priesthood → do Christians offer sacrifices?***

*"present your bodies as a sacrifice → alive, holy, and pleasing to God → which is your reasonable service."*
(Romans 12:1)

# First, the Guard

## The atoning sacrifice is finished → once for all

***"And by his will we have been made holy through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all… For by one offering he has perfected for all time those who are made holy."*** **(Hebrews 10:10, 14)**

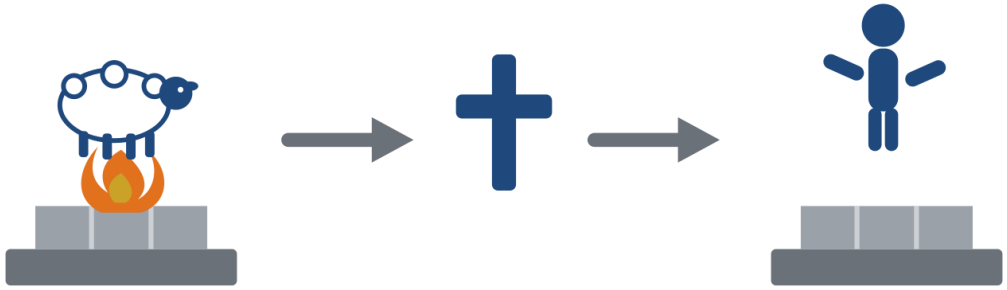
**Once for all.** The atoning work is complete, finished, unrepeatable. No altar you build, no sacrifice you offer, adds a single thing to it. It cannot be improved, only received.

**Hebrews drives it home by contrast:** the old priests stood ***daily***, offering the same sacrifices that could never take away sins (10:11). Christ offered ***one*** sacrifice and "sat down" (10:12) → the posture of finished work.

**Hold this guard the whole hour:** nothing we say next reopens the cross. Never let anyone → including yourself → put you back under a system of earning. And yet… the New Testament keeps using sacrifice language for us. Why?

# The Turn: Sacrifice Didn't End → It Changed Material

## Romans 12:1 → the Substitute has died, so now YOU go on the altar



Under the old covenant a substitute died in your place → you brought the lamb, and it went on the altar instead of you. **Now the true Substitute has died, once for all. So, what goes on the altar? You do → alive.**

***"present your bodies as a sacrifice → alive, holy, and pleasing to God → which is your reasonable service."*** **(Romans 12:1)**

The symbol has given way to the reality it always pointed toward: a whole life laid down, and kept alive to keep laying down.

## The New Covenant sacrifices, named plainly:

- Praise → *"a sacrifice of praise… the fruit of lips that confess his name"* (Heb 13:15)
- Good done & possessions shared → *"with such sacrifices God is pleased"* (Heb 13:16)
- Your very self → "a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices" (1 Pet 2:5)

# You Are the Priest

## Malachi's question arrives with no middleman

***"you are… a royal priesthood… a holy priesthood, to offer spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ."*** **(1 Pet 2:5, 9)**

**Feel the weight of that.** Malachi was written to priests → about the quality of what they brought. Peter just made you the priest. So Malachi's rebuke now arrives at your door with no one standing in between.

***"When you present blind animals for sacrifice, is that not wrong? … Try presenting them to your governor! Would he be pleased with you?"*** **(Malachi 1:8)**

God's point: you would not hand your employer, your commanding officer, the leftover you hand Me. The blind, the lame, the leftover → offered because it cost you nothing.

**And the standard crossed every covenant untouched → the best, the whole, the unblemished:**

***"I will not offer to the LORD my God burnt sacrifices that cost me nothing."*** **(2 Samuel 24:24)**

David's twelve words are the whole doctrine of cost. A sacrifice that costs nothing sacrifices nothing.

# Body AND Mind

## Romans 12:1–2 is Hebrews 5:14 → one paragraph

***"present your bodies as a sacrifice… (2) Do not be conformed to this present world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may test and approve what is the will of God → what is good and well-pleasing and perfect."*** **(Romans 12:1–2)**

**Verse 1 puts the body on the altar. Verse 2 puts the mind.** And look WHY the mind is renewed: "so that you may test and approve… what is good."

**That is Hebrews 5:14 in Paul's handwriting.** The renewed mind exists to discern the Good → the exact faculty the whole course has been training (Week 5). The living sacrifice and trained discernment are not two subjects. They are verses one and two of the same paragraph.

**So daily renewal in the Word is not preparation for your sacrifice.** It IS your sacrifice → the daily portion of it. The mind laid on the altar every morning is the offering, not the warm-up.

**Mercy first, altar second → a thank offering, not a payment.**

# Discussion

## Ten minutes → this is the week's practice

**1.** If your time this week were an animal brought to Malachi's altar, what condition would it be in → the best of the flock, or the blind and lame?

**2.** What are the "first minutes" of your day currently given to? What would change if they went on the altar?

*This is a mirror, not a measuring stick → grace already holds you; the question is what you're bringing in return.*

# Read Like a Berean

**For next week → and a unit turns**

## For next week, read:

- 1 Corinthians 14:26–40 → Paul orders public worship. What governs who may do what → and what does v.37 claim?
- Jude 3 → "the faith once for all entrusted to the saints." What does "entrusted" imply about where authority comes from?

**Next week begins Unit IV → God's House:** *Apostolic Appointment → where does teaching authority in the church come from? Two weeks of careful, contested ground.*

**Carry this week in one sentence:**

***Sacrifice didn't end → it changed material. You are the priest, and you are the offering, alive.***

***"I will not offer… sacrifices that cost me nothing." (2 Samuel 24:24)***

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